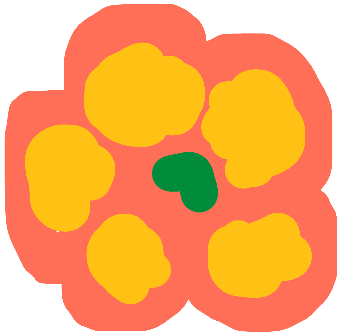


Listening Skills

"We have two ears and one mouth so that we can listen twice as much as we speak." –Epictetus

Source: *Technical Communication* By Meenakshi Raman & Sangeeta Sharma, Third Edition

Listening- An Introduction

- Def.- Listening is a process of receiving, interpreting, and reacting to a message received from the speaker.
- It's a skill
- Can be acquired and mastered
- Like reading, involves reception & decoding of verbal messages
- Communication process is incomplete without listening
- Studies show business people spend 45% of their work time listening
- Acc. to management guru Tom Peters, it's a management & leadership skill

Listening Vs. Hearing

- We tend to assume that listening and hearing are same.
- This is a misconception that leads us to believe that effective listening is instinctive.
- As a result we make little effort to develop listening skills.
- Listening, unlike hearing, involves a more sophisticated mental process than hearing.
- It demands energy and discipline.

Poor Listening Habits

- Listening but not hearing
- Rehearsing
- Interrupting
- Hearing what is expected
- Listening for a point of disagreement

- Labelling the subject matter uninteresting
- Criticizing the delivery or appearance of the speaker
- Being too stimulated
- Trying to outline everything that is being said
- Listening only for facts

Traits of a Good Listener

- Being Non-Evaluative
- Paraphrasing
- Reflecting Implications
- Reflecting Hidden Feelings
- lnviting Further Contributions
- Responding Non-verbally

Advantages of Good Listening

- Helps obtain information
- Helps solve problems
- Develops better relations
- Helps to know the organization
- Helps in framing plans and policies
- Helps to share experiences
- Helps in decision-making
- Provides encouragement

Types of Listening

Appreciative Listening- Listening for aesthetic pleasure

Empathetic Listening- Listening to understand the speaker's emotions, circumstances, mindset, and perspective so as to provide moral and emotional support, eg. A nurse listening to a patient

Comprehensive Listening-Listening to interpret or comprehend/understand . Eg. Students listening to a lecture

Critical/ Evaluative/ Judgemental/ Interpretive Listening- Listening involves analysing, evaluating, and judging what is said. Eg. Listening to a salesperson before making a purchase or listening to a politician making their election campaign speech

Superficial Listening- Same as hearing or passive listening. Eg. When one is forced to attend a guest lecture on an area that is not of one's interest

'You' viewpoint- Giving the speaker more importance than our own self is listening with a 'you' viewpoint.

Barriers to Effective Listening

- Content
- Speaker
- Medium
- Distractions
- Mindset
- Language
- Listening speed
- Feedback
- Cultural Barriers

Tips for Cultivating Good Listening Skills

- Be interested
- Be prepared
- Avoid talking
- Concentrate
- Avoid distractions
- Put the Speaker at ease
- Be open-minded
- Avoid contradictions

- Avoid Interruptions
- Empathize with the speaker
- Listen to the main points
- Take notes
- Summarize and evaluate
- Provide feedback